complicit Bairam Khan who could then consolidate not just the imperial power, but also his own ambitions. Now the harem had blindsided Bairam Khan, questioning his motives, and forming an unexpected barrier between the Padshah and his guardian. For Akbar had implicit and profound trust in these women. Not just in his mother, Hamida Banu, but also his aunt, Gulbadan, stepmother, Bega Begum, and his milk mothers, Maham Anaga and Jiji Anaga. Throughout his life he would show them extravagant devotion and would grant them their smallest wishes. He would never forsake a single one of them and would mourn them, long after they were gone. To have to reconcile the clashing desires of these two factions would have necessarily troubled and exasperated the young emperor.

When the Mughal camp arrived in Lahore a few days after Akbar, Bairam Khan renewed his accusations, this time attacking the Padshah's foster father, Shamsuddin Ataka Khan. 'Since from time to time I find His Majesty lacking in favour,' wrote Bairam Khan angrily, 'I must attribute it to your backbiting and slander. What have I done that you are inimical to me and, thirsty for my blood, you cause the emperor's temperament to deviate? Will you go so far that he will make an attempt on my life?' These were grave and calculated accusations and Ataka was unsettled enough to rally his relatives and appear before Bairam Khan to swear fealty to the powerful khankhanan. Ataka Khan, Akbar's devoted old foster father, was sent away to Bhira by Bairam Khan soon after thus eliminating another of the young Padshah's old retainers. In Lahore there was now further cause for Bairam Khan to be satisfied for he was reunited with his wife, a princess of Mewat,* and his infant son, Abdur Rahim.

Within a few months, when the Mughal camp was stationed at Jalandhar on its way to Delhi, Bairam Khan reminded Akbar of a promise Humayun had made to wed him to the young Salima Sultan Begum, a granddaughter of Babur, and therefore a Timurid princess. The women of the harem, we are told, especially Maham Anaga, exerted themselves greatly and arranged for this marriage within a week. Akbar, through his biographer Abu'l Fazl, later expressed his scorn at the presumption on the part of Bairam Khan to wish to ally himself to the royal family itself. However, at the age of fifteen, Akbar was not strong enough yet to directly oppose the khankhanan. This was an exalted connection indeed for Bairam Khan and further exposed his soaring ambitions. That Maham Anaga was keen to placate the khankhanan implied that she felt uneasy under his suspicious scrutiny. The harem, and